

KF 43 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Try me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any hurtful way in me, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

I hope that you have taken a few minutes each day to practice **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. You may discover that this technique relaxes your body and refreshes your mind. In our stressful world, we all need to learn how to calm our creaturely reactions of fight or flight. We all have work to do, and we want to enjoy the benefits of our work. Techniques that help us to both enjoy our work and work more productively make our lives satisfying and a lot more fun.

Let’s begin with a body scan to connect our minds to our marvelous bodies. Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for twenty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. *(Pause for 20 seconds)*

Now turn your attention to your feet and ankles. What sensations do you notice there? *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Take a deep breath and move your attention to your calves and knees. Do you notice anything like discomfort, pain, or twitching? Breathe and observe. Try to relax on the exhale. *(Pause of 20 seconds)*

Now begin to observe your thighs and hips. What do you notice? On the exhale, release with the breath any tension or discomfort you might find there. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Move your attention to your torso. Scan your abdomen, chest, and back. Observe, and then release with the breath any tension you might find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Move to your neck and shoulders. Breathe, adjust, and release. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Observe your face. Breathe and relax any tightness or tension you find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Begin **Alternate Nostril Breathing**, switching nostrils on the exhale. You can breathe naturally, or you might use the **Three-Part Breath** or the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹ Practice for three minutes. I will give you one-minute markers. *(Pause for 3 minutes announcing each minute as it passes)*

Pause. It is beneficial to begin your meditation practice with a few minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. This breathing technique can also help to clear your mind for work and creativity and to calm your body for sleep.

Our hymn for KF Confession 10 is *O Worship the King*. This hymn praises God for the care that He provides for us through the flow of the Creation.

Thy bountiful care, what tongue can recite?
It breathes in the air, it shines in the light;
It streams from the hills, it descends to the plain,
And sweetly distills in the dew and the rain.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We are reminded in KF Confession 10 that in order to actualize our potential we have to honor our real limitations:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

WE, W-E, is a nurturing support group for parents.³ In the group's 1989 newsletter we read:

Becoming who we truly are capable of becoming in the fullest sense could be called the journey of life. Such an on-going, ever-expanding art eludes a tight description and perhaps can only be hinted at as the art of simultaneously being and becoming . . . The person who is adept at becoming will not always be described as happy, but will often handle both the joy and the pain of life with acceptance and grace.

Quotes like these help us define the characteristics of the True Self—a fulfilled creature who is both being and becoming at the same time while gracefully accepting the joy and the pain of a real life.

Last week, I introduced the tool of doing the MATH—M-A-T-H. Before beginning any new enterprise, we do the MATH and consider whether we have the Money, Abilities, Time, and Health to accomplish our goals. When we make decisions about our lives, we are setting priorities. Oriented priorities acknowledge that we have limited resources, and by doing the MATH we honor the limitations of those resources. We cannot do it all, be it all, experience it all, and have it all, but the market economy wants to enslave you by making you believe that you can. Your fear of missing out becomes a primary motivation for playing the Idol's game of limitless possibilities. This game deceives you into believing that you can overlook or push through real limitations—but your real limitations will always win in the end. The search for the *Glory of Me!* is a kind of premeditated disappointment that invites self-hate and leaves you feeling chronically discontented with your life.

The market economy is not interested in either God's priorities or yours. It has its own priorities, and by selling you the idea that you can have it all and do it all, it tempts you to mindlessly waste your resources

fulfilling its priorities. If you choose to buy into the market culture, you will end up dissipating the resources that God intended for the development of your True Self and mission. When you disregard your limitations and neglect your oriented priorities, you invite into your life forces that drive you into the wrong pasture with the wrong bull—or into the hunter’s snare.

In our last lesson, I talked about debt. In any area of the MATH, we can inherit debt from others or fall into debt by overextending ourselves. As a result, we find ourselves with fewer resources for doing what is really important. Perhaps you are in debt today—whether in your money, your abilities, your time, or your health. In the Proverbs we learn that the debtor is the lender’s slave, and if you go into debt in any area of the MATH, you will find yourself enslaved.⁴ As a slave, you are no longer the driving power in your life; you are forced to submit to the will of your taskmasters. Your unrealistic choices create debt, and with debt come self-generated limitations that you must then accommodate. It is possible that you actually choose to go into debt to avoid your real glory and the freedom to explore your real potential. When we are in debt, we are like children entangled in a net that must be cut away before we can explore the fascinating house into which we were born.

The consequences of debt are perhaps best understood in the context of money. No matter how much money we have, we need to handle it as a limitation. Money is a finite resource, which, if used poorly, creates destructive limitations in other areas of the MATH. When we understand money as a limitation, we approach it with humility and with the confidence and peace that come from living in reality. The skills that we learn when budgeting money can be applied to every area of our MATH.

I know a woman who has chosen to look carefully at her closet and plan her wardrobe. Even though she has plenty of resources, she has imposed financial limitations on her spending, based on her needs during the last year. She is finding great freedom in the limitation of having fewer clothes and ones that work well together. She is now enjoying the simplicity of less clutter in her environment. By imposing limitations on her spending, she invites God and the Creation to circulate with her—and God’s surprise of a sale item or a gift from a friend invites her into deeper relationship. As you can imagine, this all requires a growing trust that God, others, and the Creation will care for you if you do not snatch and grab for yourself.

The best environment for learning a new skill is often one that provides restrictions. Teachers, coaches, “how to” articles, and self-directed language courses (and even KF!) all use restrictions to help students learn as efficiently as possible and achieve proficiency in new skills more easily. We cannot become proficient in a skill by doing whatever we please. We rely on restrictions, or boundaries, to hold us on course while we explore, make mistakes—and, often, feel very frustrated. Without boundaries we cannot be trained. Boundaries provide security and reduce our anxiety while we grapple with the challenge of learning new skills.

Living without restrictions may seem like freedom, but it actually creates anxiety and the feeling that you don’t belong. Children who are allowed to do anything they want and go wherever they please lack the guiding limitations that are indispensable for training. If they are not given boundaries, they do not develop self-worth; they assume that they are not valuable enough to be attended to, protected, and trained. People who are raised this way suffer in their souls. They are afraid of life, afraid of others, and afraid of themselves.

Limitations help us set priorities because they reduce and simplify the scope of possibilities. A KF member worked long hours to provide for his family. Each week he offered to his church one or two hours of his time. When the church asked him to do more, he very confidently refused. The limitations of his finances

did not allow him the luxury of contributing more to his community. His priorities were clear: to earn what he could, to spend time with his family, and to contribute to his community. This man is now able to earn more money in less time, which stretches the limitations of his MATH. He can, therefore, offer more to his community while maintaining his priorities.

Without training, our souls remain underdeveloped and egocentric, and in that condition we cannot offer anything worthwhile to our community. Our sense of impoverishment prevents us from letting anything go; we hope that by hoarding we can fill the void within. With training, however, we can break the cycle of impoverishment by offering to our children noble thoughts, words, and deeds so that they become wealthy adults who are able to give and receive in a karis relationship. By your example, show your children how to circulate within the confines of the family, and then help them expand their contribution into the community and the world.

People can stagnate in their wealth or in their poverty, and when they do, they live with a chronic sense of entitlement. For these people, there is never enough to make up for the hole in their soul. That hole creates a huge debt which they externalize onto everyone else. In their mind, it is now the responsibility of the world to pay that debt, so they expect and demand from others deference, support, and unquestioning service. Accountability feels like an assault against them. Gaping and compulsive needs, which nothing seems to satisfy, become their justification for demanding or taking anything they want and giving nothing in return.

Budgeting programs help you maintain your financial priorities. YNAB, an acronym for You Need A Budget, is an effective online budgeting tool for managing uncomplicated finances.⁵ It costs a minimal amount and there are trial options. The Dave Ramsey course, known as the Financial Peace University, has helped many people find financial freedom from the slavery of debt.⁶ You might also explore a free budgeting tool at www.mint.com. Find out what works for you. If your finances are complicated or your financial resources are extensive, you might employ a financial professional to ground you in the reality of what your money is for and to help you be accountable. Too much money can deceive you into ignoring other areas of the MATH, causing you to go into debt in those areas. For example, if you can afford to buy expensive products and health treatments to support your lifestyle and yet continue to ignore your body's needs, you will eventually find yourself in debt to your health.

Please remember that if more than one person is involved in your money, you will need to work together; it isn't healthy for anyone's development if one person makes all the financial decisions. Many people use money and their power over the management of money to alleviate their fear, protect their pride, and control others. Take the Believe It Path. Recognize that money invites power struggles, and use your KF skills to maintain healthy boundaries while promoting an atmosphere of non-judgment, respect, and cooperation.

It's in the Idol's best interests to resist your efforts to keep track of money and learn how to use financial resources wisely. Your Idol wants you to feel anxious about money and will encourage you to use money to support its shoulds and claims. The anxious emotions of need and greed pressure you to return to the Idol's culture of compulsive spending, snatching, and hoarding, all of which lead to stagnation and misorientation. With a budget, however, your True Self will have the freedom to explore money within the limitations of reality. You can then learn to circulate your financial resources confidently by earning, spending, saving, and giving.

The next area of the MATH to consider is the limited resource of our abilities. No matter how smart you

are, your abilities are limited. I wasted years stubbornly refusing to accept the limitation of my abilities and created much more suffering for myself than was necessary for my training. I have never done well working with numbers. They are too abstract for me, so I have asked for budgeting help from someone who handles numbers easily. I know that whenever I adventure into numbers, self-hate will be waiting for me, but with my KF tools I can now manage that self-hate. For now, when it comes to numbers, I ask for help.

A young friend came to help me clean and organize my house. I have limited abilities in that area, also. When we decided to move my heavy old box TV, she picked it up, all by herself, and took it to another room. I was cackling after her like a mother hen whose chick had just picked up the henhouse, but she has ability. She is an athlete, and picking up the TV was within her abilities. Someday, I may have that ability, but I don't try to pick up TVs right now. I am honoring my limitations while making efforts to expand my potential. I get help.

I had an opportunity to help my adventurous young granddaughter learn about the limitation of her abilities. When we were playing in the water together, she decided that she no longer needed her arm floaties, so we took them off. She then climbed onto the edge of the pool and jumped in. Of course, she immediately sank under the water. I respectfully lifted her above the water and asked her what she wanted to do next. She said that she wanted to put her floaties back on. We both approached her experiment with non-judgment and then peacefully adjusted to her new appreciation for limitations.

You will never wear a petite if you are tall, nor can you change your race or genetics; and if you are a man, you cannot become a woman. But within the real and fixed limitations of your design, you have a mission, and you can grow. As you grow, so do your possibilities, and you may find that some of the limitations that at one time you believed to be fixed are now stretching or have even disappeared. Choices that honor your MATH today will lead to more flexibility tomorrow. What may not be possible for you now may become possible in your future. Remember ASAP: ask God and others for help; simplify your life; adventure into opportunities that will stretch your limitations; set your priorities according to the money, abilities, time, and health that are actually yours today. Then make courageous, oriented, real choices that may require some endurance but will cultivate your potential in Christ. A more flexible tomorrow won't materialize by magic, but it might seem like magic when God meets you and supports you in your oriented efforts.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, show me how to stretch my limitations. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 10 encourages us to use our resources wisely:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

The Bible has a lot to say about money, and you may have studied for yourself what the Bible teaches about this important resource for our lives. Unfortunately, money is a big issue in most religious organizations, so these organizations tend to have strong views about money that are often motivated by particular beliefs. Teachings about money may also be motivated by need or greed. Do your own research to help you decide how you want to circulate your money. You can read a clear and dispassionate presentation of the subject of tithing on Wikipedia.⁷ Right now, however, I am more interested in helping you see that every area of the MATH has its own limitations.

Let's look at a prayer from **Proverbs 30:7–9** in my paraphrase, which blends together my translations of the original Hebrew and Greek texts.

⁷I have asked You, Lord, for two things. Do not withhold this favor before I die. ⁸Keep useless idolatry and deceitful business at a safe distance from me. Grant neither deprivation nor excess. Feed me with the bite-size morsels that are my portion and appropriate for my current level of development, teaching me mature self-sufficiency. ⁹For if You don't do this, I might become filled with deceitful ideas and say to myself, "I am not accountable to anyone." Or, I might become an impoverished outcast and steal from others, using Your authority deceptively.

Take a deep breath.

Whenever you read a Bible passage that teaches about riches and poverty, think about your limitations in all the areas of the MATH, not just in your bank account. These wise sayings or proverbs about the human condition have been passed down for millennia because over and over again they have proved to be true. If you are human, this probably means that you are no exception to this wisdom! The wisdom of the Bible applies to you.

We see in this prayer two requests—and only two! That's so simple! The first request is to be set apart into truth and remain connected to reality. The skill of recognizing real evidence and acting on proven principles protects us from deceiving ourselves and being deceived by others. Truth presents one of our great limitations. We cannot stretch the limitations of truth to fit our idealized judgments about how things should be. When we twist the truth or make up a story that supports our judgments and illusions, we are deceiving ourselves. Our misplaced loyalty to our beliefs about what life *should* be prevents us from recognizing what is real. We must then use our precious energy to hide the truth both from ourselves and from others. When reality can no longer be avoided, we must spend more resources cleaning up the mess that we've created because we ignored the limitations of truth in the first place.

Let's assume that in an effort to survive you have become adept at deceiving both yourself and others and are now, consciously or unconsciously, using that skill whenever your pride system is threatened. Your story about threat justifies your choice to deceive. If you want God to protect you from deception, whether in yourself or in others, you will have to learn to live in the truth. We need to develop the courage to deal in truth rather than take refuge in deception, which is one of the cheap habitual shortcuts that our Idol uses to calm our fear and restore our pride. Acting on real evidence and proven principles guides back into the path of orientation energies that we have formerly used for deception. KF training teaches you how to live in reality and gives you tools that help you cooperate with God as He works to keep you safe from deception and lies. If you want to give up the whole world of deceit and experience God's protection, you must learn to live in the truth. That is a limitation.

The second request in this prayer concerns wealth—wealth in money, abilities, time, or health. You can ask God to teach you how to be content with what is offered to you in your present circumstances, which may never change. Those circumstances are your portion, and they present real limitations that are specifically designed to help you cultivate your own development. Your ongoing training opportunity is to learn how to function productively within those real limitations. As you learn to manage your real limitations, you will forge the courage and authority that you need to access your true inheritance. When we make this request, we are asking God to feed and sustain us with what is possible in this material world. We ask Him to intervene if we become deluded about our capabilities. We recognize the dangers of arrogant independence and real or imagined deprivation that compel us to steal from our community.

Right now, let's pray and make these two requests to God:

My God and Creator, help me learn to live in the truth so that You can protect me from the fallout of deceit. Feed me with bits of experience that are appropriate for my level of development and teach me how to look after myself. I don't want to extend beyond what I can handle and then wander into the deceptions of my Idol Self, believing that I can be independent from You. On the other hand, I don't want to feel starved or deprived and then find myself in the grip of compulsive needs. I might then be tempted to claim Your authority and judge others as responsible for my suffering. I may even want to blame You!

Take a deep breath.

Compulsive needs are the consequence of the debt we owe to God and to our own soul. In order to pursue the insatiable cravings of pride and our dreams of an idealized glory, we must consume resources that were meant to be invested in our True Self, our community, and our relationship with God. When those essential areas of our lives are neglected, our souls feel impoverished. We feel the debt. This real sense of debt drives us to take without giving and to fabricate virtue stories about why we have a right to steal from others and from God. Debt of any kind can be used to justify oppression, snatching, and greed. Perhaps we don't know that we can actually redeem our debts through oriented living, or perhaps we may simply prefer the habitual shortcuts of snatching and impoverishing ourselves and others. It is essential for your growth and your glory that you learn to use your resources to pay off the debts to your MATH. You will discover that the rate of return is much greater than you can imagine.

We are asking God for a healthy balance between more than enough and more than we can handle. We want to honor our material existence and its real limitations. We do not want to be driven by imagined limitations that justify our compulsive needs and greed. Perhaps at this point in your training you might feel that the lid is off and anything is possible for you, but that is not true. All those imagined possibilities may not be appropriate for your design or training level. But there are an almost infinite number of possibilities that God invites you to explore within the boundaries of your portion. Your portion is what you have now and where you are today. You can trust God's goodness and His ability to train you to handle wisely all the gifts that your portion offers to you.⁸

Our prayer might go something like this:

Guardian of my soul, keep deception far from me and feed me with the portion that is appropriate for me today. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion today. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold your experience in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to make up a virtue story to justify thoughts and feelings, or you may flush away thoughts or feelings before you have a chance to examine them. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider this uncomfortable area of your life*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider an uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language yet, but you can listen. For example, you might recognize what unfairness or longing feels like in your body. You might recognize courage or curiosity. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider an uncomfortable area of your life*. *(Pause)* Are you comfortable, uncomfortable, or do you feel shut down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you *consider this uncomfortable area*? What judgments do you want to make? *(Pause)* Do you want to punish or blame yourself or others? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to safely explore something uncomfortable.
- Welcome the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, who comforts us with truth.

- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁹

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for power and control.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for esteem and affection.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for security and comfort.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for my imagined outcomes. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for training and healing. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us within our real limitations. Help us do our MATH this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*The NHG book study has begun. We hope that you will join us in the study to develop your own understanding. You might also participate in karis by returning a gift of facilitation to support the new students.

*(*Except in the Jubilee Year)*

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams, and John D. Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² *O Worship the King* by Robert Grant (1779–1838), www.youtube.com/watch?v=RAyKmYD2Zg8.

³ WE is an organization founded by Jean Illsley Clark.

⁴ Prov. 22:7.

⁵ www.youneedabudget.com/.

⁶ www.financialpeace.com/.

⁷ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tithe.

⁸ Jer. 29:11.

⁹ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.